

China Robotics

EQUITY: TECHNOLOGY

Data emerges as the critical part for robotics

Volume-price divergence across four data types redraws the vendor map; dexterous hands sit on critical path to embodied AI

In our 28 June 2026 *China Robotics – Optimus ramps; China scales up as cost curves bend lower* report, we flagged that non-robot capture (tele-op, UMI, Ego) is becoming mainstream at c.20% of real-robot data cost. This report extends that call by pricing each data tier in the mix and mapping where the non-robot substitution holds — highlighting the real-machine slice remains the highest-value, most defensible pool in the mid-term.

Data becomes critical part; tele-op captures the highest hourly value in 2026E

Data collection is emerging as the critical part for humanoid robotics in 2026, with our estimated industry-level annual data demand at c.10mn hours on a c.100k-unit shipment scenario, based on our industry survey. Figure AI's (Unlisted) CEO frames the same view: *"the biggest blocker for us now of going from where we're at today to like large-scale deployment is data. We need ... enormous amount of data."* The four principal data types show a pronounced volume-price divergence: i) No-embodiment data — first-person (Egocentric / Ego) video plus UMI (Universal Manipulation Interface) — accounts for the largest share at 40–50% of total hours but commands only c.CNY100-300/hour (according to 36Kr [KRKR US, Not rated]), implying a 2026 addressable market of c.CNY1.0–1.5bn. ii) Real-machine tele-operation makes up c.30% of hours at c.CNY500-1,000/hour (according to 36Kr), translating into the largest single sub-market of c.CNY2.2–2.5bn — the highest-value tier on our read. iii) Failure-recovery data prices at c.CNY400–500/hour (based on industry survey) but remains a low-single-digit share as most players have yet to close the deployment feedback loop. iv) Simulation/synthetic data is the cheapest at c.CNY50 per 10,000 frames (according to DAMO), mapping to c.CNY0.5–0.6bn. We view tele-op and failure-recovery hours as the scarcest, highest-margin tiers in the near term, with Ego/UMI the fastest-growing volume pool. This tiered price-volume structure — cheap synthetic at the base, scarce tele-op and failure-recovery at the top — defines which vendors can build a durable moat.

Closed-loop solution is a likely defensible model

Against this backdrop, we view a software-hardware closed loop — spanning collection, transmission, evaluation, training, deployment and debugging — as the structurally defensible business model for pure-play data vendors. Standalone Data-as-a-Service (DaaS) monetizes quickly on an hourly or project basis, but as customer data volumes scale, vendors lacking an evaluation stack or brain-level capability face rising vertical-integration risk from downstream humanoid OEMs. The closed-loop model captures first-party scene data, failure samples, evaluation outputs and deployment telemetry, which we see as the pre-requisites for a genuine data reinforcing-loop and recurring revenue. Upfront investment in toolchains, hardware and on-site deployment is substantial, but we regard the long-term ceiling as commensurately higher. Based on our industry survey, payoff is tightly linked to the embodied-AI inflection: industrial use-cases (handling, sortation, machine-tending, assembly) is likely to reach a qualitative breakthrough in 2027–2028F, with humanoid shipments likely to grow meaningfully in the period; household deployment likely awaits after 2030, and with hotel/serviced-apartment cleaning the earlier wedge. Public disclosures from Physical Intelligence, NVIDIA (NVDA US, Not rated) and Lightwheel triangulate the same conclusion: simulation is a force-multiplier, not a substitute for real-machine data. $\pi 0.5$ posts c.94% success on multi-step household subtasks and 75–80% across long-horizon household task categories; NVIDIA's synthetic-motion pipeline lifts GR00T N1 real-robot performance by c.40% vs real-only training; and Lightwheel reports an optimal c.10:1 synthetic-to-real training ratio delivering an average c.30% model-performance uplift, with case-level task success rising from 60% to 85% under joint real-plus-sim training. Simulation already covers most

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handling/sortation hours, while precision assembly and contact-rich or flexible-object manipulation still require real-machine fine-tuning; household scenarios remain simulation-inadequate on a standalone basis for the next three-five years, in our view.

Size-versus-sensor trade-off defines the dexterous-hand

The reason precision assembly and contact-rich tasks resist simulation — and the reason household deployment is a post-2030 story — traces back to the hand. The dexterous-hand competitive landscape is defined by an unresolved size-versus-function trade-off: the closer the hand approximates human dimensions, the better the mapping between training-data collection and downstream operation, but shrinking form-factor leaves insufficient volume for sensor payload. Among domestic players, only one vendor is described as truly human-hand-sized, while the leading tactile-focused hand and other high-DoF designs remain visibly oversized, degrading data-to-execution coherence. Tactile technology carries its own ceiling: point-pressure sensors cannot register lateral force or slip, and current e-skin exhibits poor fidelity on lateral-force curves — even the size-leading whole-hand solution carries only c.80 pressure points. On the arm side, the market has bifurcated: harmonic-drive-plus-torque-sensor arms (e.g. the Luna/Skye family) are drifting toward industrial-manipulator territory with limited bionic character and hard-to-find humanoid use-cases (based on our industry survey). Our takeaway: high arm precision only resolves intermediate motion, whereas a sufficiently capable hand can compensate for a lower-precision arm; we prefer architectures that omit torque sensors and harmonic drives and concentrate capability at the end-effector. Transmission choices reinforce this: harmonic reducers (typical ratios 1:200–1:800) dominate, planetary reducers serve high-load leg/ankle joints, and tendon drives (c.20N/2kg) suit flexible-object handling but suffer durability limits, while linkage drives deliver force at the risk of crushing fragile items. Net-net, until hand-side dexterity and tactile fidelity close the gap, the value pool for real-machine tele-op data — and for vendors owning the closed loop that captures it — remains structurally protected, in our view.

Appendix A-1

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